

Just pennies? That's an awful lot of pennies! And with the face value of coupons increasing every year, the potential for fraudulent redemption and counterfeit coupons has increased as well.

According to a CPGMatters August 2012 report, Inmar has seen submissions of counterfeit coupons increase by more than 20 percent in the first half of 2012. "Counterfeiters are getting more aggressive and more sophisticated, making it more and more difficult for cashiers to stop this fraud at the point of sale," Matthew Tilley, director of Marketing of Inmar Promotion Network was quoted as saying.

Advancing technology has brought some solutions to identifying counterfeit coupons. Besides the new GS1 Data Bar and the ability to serialize coupons, the Coupon Information Center (CIC), a nonprofit association founded to encourage integrity in connection with the redemption of manufacturer's coupons, offers a hologram that can be printed on coupons and an early warning system for retailers and CIC members. Known counterfeit coupons are also posted on the CIC website.

As I perused archives from as far back as 2003, I was shocked to see one of the counterfeit coupons listed was for a free package of Twizzlers licorice. Why? Because in the late 1990s I'd used several free Twizzlers coupons a woman had sent me in response to an ad I'd run in a refund bulletin. Had I used a fraudulent coupon? If a thirty-year veteran of the coupon world had been so easily fooled by a bogus coupon, how could a less-experienced cashier or coupon user know the difference between a genuine and a fake?